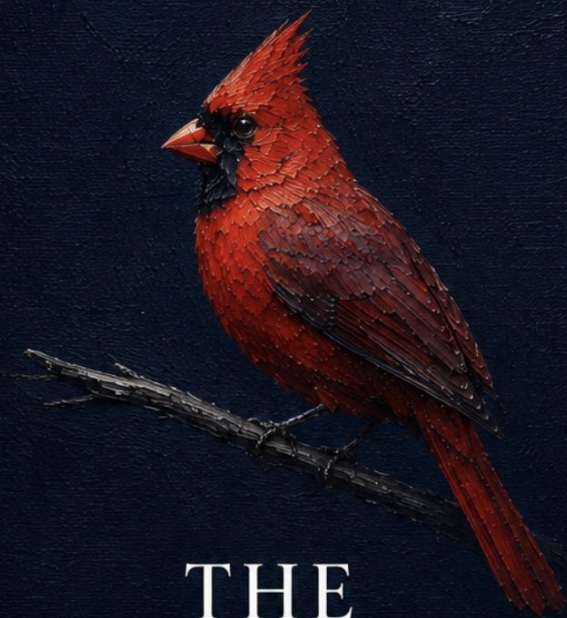


"I've known this man for thirty-five years. You can trust what you're about to read."

— DAVE MEYER, former NFL quarterback



THE CARDINAL'S PROMISE

A Memoir of the Father Who Stayed

ROB BRIZZI

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This is a work of memoir. It reflects the author's present recollections of experiences over time. Some names and identifying details have been changed, some dialogue has been reconstructed, and some events are rendered as composites, as described in the Author's Note.

*For anyone who has struggled with addiction or loved someone who
has*

*In honor of Lou Brizzi —
the man who kept showing up.*

1941–2025

For Hope, who tilted her head and said “We?”

THE CARDINAL'S PROMISE

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PROLOGUE

“He brought me up out of an horrible pit, out of the miry clay, and set my feet upon a rock.” — Psalm 40:2

Tijuana, Mexico, 2005

His hands were already around my throat before I understood he had crossed the cell. Small man. Moving too fast. Wired on meth or something close enough that his whole body carried the unstable energy of someone who might come apart without warning. Somebody in the dark made a snarling sound, low and animal. Somebody else said his name. Rico. Nobody moved to stop him. Even in here, the others feared him. His face came an inch from mine. The only English he had came out in a rasp.

“Gringo. Gringo. Money.”

Of course he knows how to say money.

“No tengo dinero,” I told him. It came out begging — thin and high, a voice I didn’t recognize as mine. It was true. They had already taken everything.

“Money. Money.” One hand came off my throat and he rubbed his fingers against his thumb, the money sign from every movie ever made, while the other hand kept its grip. The fingers pressed. Eased.

Pressed again. His breath was sour and chemical, hot against my mouth. Then the hands dropped. He muttered something, backed to the wall, and the dark took him.

The night had started ordinary. A workday. A Tuesday in my San Diego years. When I was done I crossed into Tijuana the way I always did — for the pharmacies, for the pills my prescriptions back home could no longer keep up with. I wasn't sober that night. I'd been using in Tijuana since I crossed, and I was down to the last of my supply — to an addict, an emptying bottle is the only emergency that counts. I'd crossed enough times that I thought I understood how it worked. That was the problem. Do something dangerous often enough and it stops feeling dangerous. It starts to feel like an errand.

This time a cop saw the watch.

He was on foot, working the strip near the crossing, and he slowed when he passed my window the way they do when they've already decided something. He circled back. Tapped the glass with two fingers. I rolled it down because there was nothing else to do with a tap like that. His eyes went to my wrist before they went to my face. I'd worn the watch because it made me feel like the man I was pretending to be. Now it was the reason a cop in Tijuana had stopped walking. This was not a traffic stop. I hadn't broken a law he cared about. He'd seen something he wanted on the arm of a man nobody would come looking for.

He said something I couldn't understand. He didn't say it loud. He didn't need to. I got out.

He had the watch off my wrist inside a minute. Then the bag. Then everything else in my pockets, one item at a time, no hurry in it anywhere, and the no-hurry was the part that scared me. For a moment I thought that might be the end of it, that I'd be sent back across the line with one more story I'd never tell. Then he took my arm and walked me to a car that wasn't marked like the ones on TV. No lights. A plain sedan with a man in the passenger seat who never

turned around. A hand on my shoulder put me in the back. The car smelled musty, like old smoke had soaked into the seats and stayed. He said things from the front I couldn't understand, and then he stopped saying anything. Some part of me kept running the old math, telling me this was a toll, a cost of doing business, a story I'd never tell. Then I reached for the door and there was no handle on the inside, and the math stopped working.

I don't know how long we drove. Long enough for the streets outside the window to lose their lights. When the car stopped, the door opened from the outside — of course it did — and the hand came back.

It walked me through a metal door and down a hallway that got darker the deeper we went. Voices somewhere ahead of us. No desk. No paperwork. Nobody asked my name, and nobody wrote it down anywhere. That landed one step at a time: there was going to be no record that I was here. At the end of the hall, a man pulled a door open. The hand let go of my arm, and something between a push and a shove put me through.

It wasn't a prison. It was a holding cell in a building I could never have found again. I didn't know where I was, who knew I was there, or how long they meant to keep me.

The smell reached me before the door shut.

Sewer. Vomit. Mold. Sweat over the top of it. Something rotten and sweet underneath that stuck to the back of the throat. I gagged on it, swallowed, gagged again. When the door closed, the dark seemed to move. I stood still and waited for my eyes to adjust. They didn't. Not really. Shapes shifted. Breathing came from every direction — wet, close, uneven. In the corner a cough ran too long and ended in a rattle. A rat crossed the floor, claws on concrete, and was gone.

The men spoke Spanish faster than I could follow. It had been my first language once. Mexico was where I started. By now it was

buried far enough down that I could hear it without holding it, and the words moved past me in pieces.

Some of the men were gone in the head — rocking, laughing, talking to no one. Others sat with their backs to the wall and their eyes empty. A few just watched me. I didn't belong there and they knew it. Rico was one of the ones who watched.

My throat burned. I wanted to put a hand to it and didn't. I wasn't going to let the room see. I slid down the wall instead and sat, knees to my chest, the concrete cold through my clothes, my forehead down. I knew the position. My body found it before my mind caught up. Get small. Stay quiet. Don't hold anyone's eye. Don't give the room a reason to pick you. It was the same shape I'd folded into as a boy when the yelling started.

There was no bedroom this time. No hallway light. And no one on earth knew where I was.

Not my father. Not my brother. Not my mother. No one.

I sat on a concrete floor in Mexico with my head on my knees, and the life I'd been performing was somewhere else. What was left was the smell, the dark, and my own breathing.

The high was wearing off. I could feel the far edge of it, the place where the sick starts, and somewhere underneath the counting had already begun — how long since the last pill, how long until the need got loud. If somebody had opened that door and offered me the outside without my drugs or the pit with them, I would have chosen the pit. That is the truest thing I can tell you about that night.

I lost track of time. The voices flattened into noise. I thought about my mother, her hand around mine in the airport when I was four, the woman who carried me out of this country to give me a life. I'd come back to take myself apart. Then my father, Lou. That was worse. He'd chosen me — a boy from Mexico City who wasn't his — made me his son, gave me his name, sat in the bleachers and paid the bills and handed over money he didn't have, and never once

PROLOGUE

made me feel I had to earn the place. Somewhere back home he was asleep, believing his son was safe. And I'd put myself here.

I wanted to pray and couldn't. I still believed, somewhere under it. Asking for help out of a hole I'd dug myself was more than I could do.

The door opened. Light cut in. I looked up and stayed where I was, afraid it was for someone else, afraid to stand too fast. A man said something and waved me forward. I got up. My legs were wrong under me. I stepped around the wet places and around the men, past Rico, who didn't look at me. Outside the air wasn't clean, but it was air. Someone handed me back a fold of my own money, enough to get across the line and home. Not all of it. Enough.

I came back the next day.

PART ONE

THE ESCAPE

CHAPTER 1 ## Mexico City — The Escape

“The LORD shall preserve thy going out and thy coming in from this time forth, and even for evermore.” — Psalm 121:8

Mexico City, 1982

“Claudio,” my mother said, “you will love this story.”

That summer she was obsessed with *E.T.* The movie wasn’t even out yet, but she’d already tracked down and read the paperback. One afternoon she sat me down to explain it. She told me about an alien left behind by his spaceship, and the boy who hid him in his room to try to get him home.

“What are aliens?” I asked.

She stopped and thought for a second.

“People,” she said. “Just from somewhere so far away you can’t even imagine it.”

I closed my eyes and tried to picture people from that far away. I couldn’t. I couldn’t even picture the people who lived two blocks from our apartment.

The only world I knew was Mexico City. I was four years old.

We lived in Bosques de Aragón, in a two-story brick row house on a dead-end street, the houses wrapped around a patch of grass. The walls were thick and you heard everything anyway. Radios. Fights. The street vendors shouting before sunrise. Music from passing cars and open windows. Overhead, old sneakers hung by their laces from the power lines, swinging in the breeze.

Rosa María and Armando lived next door. A clothesline ran between our balconies, always full of sheets drying stiff under the hot sun. Every morning started the same way: my mother put a pot of beans on the stove, and the whole house filled with the smell. Beans, onions, sugar, and the warm bread she bought from the bakery on the corner.

My mother taught English at a little preschool called Cascabelito. Little Bell. Because she worked there, I got to go for free. In the afternoons she'd put on music and dance around the kitchen while making tacos. She would scoop my little brother, Chris, up on her hip and sing along to "The Locomotion," and I'd dance right next to her because she was happy. That was all the reason I needed.

My mother, Becky, had followed my father to Mexico because she loved him. Blonde and American, she stood out on our street, and she stayed anyway. She learned Spanish from soap operas, built a life in the middle of Mexico City, and chose him even when the people who loved her most questioned the decision. She always made her own way. Chris and I were born from that courage. Or stubbornness. She needed both.

I didn't understand the sacrifice. I knew the smell of dinner, the music playing in the kitchen, and her hand reaching down to hold mine.

My papa was a proud man. He worked a government job, and every morning he left the house in pressed clothes. He'd take off running and I'd come after him and we'd race. He always got there first. Then he'd turn around with a grin and say, "Wow, you're fast today." I believed him every time.

He bought me my own record player, a Fisher-Price like the neighbor's. One day he came home excited about a promotion and picked me up. "Claudio," he said, "you are my good luck charm." Olive skin, high cheekbones, a strong jawline, a face built for the grin he was wearing. That was my name then. Claudio Horacio

Balderas — his own name folded into the middle of mine. When my father looked at you, you were the center of the world. He told me he was proud of me and I ran around the house like I owned it.

At night he told me a story, his voice low, like every word mattered. The rabbit in the moon. He said a long time ago a god came down and walked the earth as a tired old man, hungry, and the only one who shared what little he had was a small rabbit. To thank him, the god lifted the rabbit up and pressed his shape into the moon, so anyone who looked up would remember. “Look,” Papa would say, pointing out the window at the moon. “He’s still up there.” I’d beg him to tell it again, and he always would. Just the two of us in the dark, and I never wanted it to end.

I did not know why he sometimes disappeared. I did not know why Mama was afraid. I only knew that when he came home, I wanted him to read me the rabbit story again.

But there was another side to Papa. He’d sit in cafés after work, playing chess, drinking coffee, not coming home. Some weekends he slept straight through, and his own father had to come and wake him. One Thanksgiving my mom cooked the whole dinner, and Papa never got up for it. Other times he left for work and didn’t come back. A day. Then two. Then three. Then he’d walk in worn out, his eyes gone somewhere, go straight to the bedroom, lock the door, and shut the house out.

I’d push the door open a crack and look in. He was always asleep.

Then he’d come out and act as if nothing had happened. We’d have dinner. He’d read to me until I fell asleep.

I never knew which Papa I was going to get. It took me years to understand I’d been watching two different men.

When my mother pushed back, it turned. One night it went physical, a single slap, and that one time told her plainly what the locked doors and the disappearances had only hinted at — that the

drinking had him, and the man it left behind was someone she could no longer predict. His family knew, and they took his side. She had warned them more than once that she was going to leave. They answered that if she did, they would keep one of us. The threat to take a child was the thing she could not live with. In the end, that's why we left.

That's the reason, and I believe it. I'd add one thing that's only my read on her. She wasn't happy in that marriage, and I think she looked around and decided America might be better for her boys. I can't speak for her.

There's a picture of me from back then. A little kid in a Mickey Mouse shirt washed so many times it had gone gray, though Mickey still held his color. I wore it until it fell apart.

After Mama and Papa, I loved Marcelo, my older cousin. A few years ahead of me, which at that age is a whole generation, and I followed him everywhere. One day he took me to the market for gum. He walked me down the rows, naming things, while I looked at all of it. The gum came in big wrappers in every color, and there was one flavor every kid in the neighborhood wanted. Mango. We found it. I walked home with a piece of it in my cheek.

My mom got pregnant with Chris when I was two; he was born just before I turned three. The week before, I wouldn't let my mother put me down. I'd grab her hips while she walked and let her drag me along the floor. "Let me down," she kept saying. I didn't want down. I wanted to be carried. She told me she couldn't carry me anymore because there was going to be another baby. I asked if the baby could be mine. She said yes.

When she came through the door with him I climbed up on the couch next to her. "Is that my baby? Can I hold him?" She put him in my arms. He let out a thin little cry and I didn't know what to do with it. "Okay," I said. "I'll try again later." And I handed him back.

For years I told Chris he'd been small enough to fit in my pocket when he was born. He believed me. That was the fun part of having a little brother. He believed everything you said.

Chris cried a lot as a baby. His ears, my mother said. She'd hold him for hours. I'd go to my room and play the same record again. But I got used to it. He was mine, after all. I'd asked, and she'd said yes.

I don't remember every detail of those first years in Mexico. Memories from when you are two, three, and four don't come back as whole stories. They come back in pieces. One of them is Marcelo's birthday party, the piñata breaking open, candy spilling everywhere. They must be rich, I remember thinking. Look at all that candy.

Mexico was home.

After several years of marriage my mother had seen enough. Love was never the question. She didn't announce anything. She got our passports quietly and said we were going to New Jersey to visit Grandpa. Two weeks. Like every other trip. I believed her completely.

When we packed for New Jersey, my mama told me I could bring four shirts.

"I want my Mickey Mouse shirt," I said. The one from the picture — gray with a black collar and red and yellow designs on the front, washed soft. Papa had given it to me.

"It's too small," she said.

"No. Now it fits just right."

She let me pack it.

Papa stood in the hallway with a folded newspaper under his arm. "I'll see you in two weeks," he said. He believed it too. My mother kissed him. "I love you," she said. I hugged him goodbye. I think I had the Mickey Mouse shirt on.

Chris was about a year and a half when we left Mexico. Hazel eyes, light skin. Not like me.

Then the airport. My mother carried a suitcase and Chris while I dragged a little red one behind me. I'd flown once before, to Houston, when I was two and a half, the trip to see Aunt Terry when Kevin was born, but I didn't remember any of it. As far as I knew, I'd never seen a plane up close. The engines came up through the floor and the seat and into me. When we started down the runway something pushed me back into my seat. I looked out the window. The houses and the streets slid by, slow and then fast, until they ran together and dropped away under the clouds.

The only world I'd ever known was gone. I didn't know that's what I was watching. I thought I'd see it again in two weeks.

My mom showed me how to pop my ears. I blew too hard and it scared me. Then I put my head on her arm and fell asleep.

She sat awake. The whole flight she was waiting for someone to stop her, at the gate, in the aisle, at the door. She held her breath, ready to be pulled off the plane before it took off. She was leaving the country where she'd tried to build a life with a man she loved and couldn't live with. The school with the little bell. The cul-de-sac, the grass, the thick walls, Rosa María and Armando next door. She was walking away from all of it on purpose, and she couldn't grieve any of it yet — not out loud, not with her son asleep on her arm still believing it was a two-week trip.

We landed in New Jersey at the start of winter. The airport felt like home at first. Same crowds, same noise, everyone rushing. Then I started listening. The words were wrong. Not Spanish. Something else. Everybody around me knew something I didn't.

CHAPTER 2 ## New Jersey: Survival

*“Strength and honour are her clothing; and she shall rejoice
in time to come.” — Proverbs 31:25*

West Paterson, New Jersey, 1983

My aunt Nancey picked us up in her small red Honda Civic and drove us to Cedar Grove, to the house my mother had grown up in. I stepped outside and saw my own breath for the first time. I didn't know that could even happen. I'd only seen smoke like that come off a cigarette. The three of us crowded in there for two or three months before moving to a bigger house in West Paterson.

My Spanish disappeared almost overnight. English was everywhere. I picked it up the way kids do, without deciding to. Back home I'd had a lisp. In New Jersey they sent me to speech therapy twice a week to fix the way I talked. Decades later it still comes out at the worst times.

My grandfather was strict, or so my mother said. He'd never approved of the marriage, but he let us stay with him. We paid him eight hundred a month. Chris and I never saw that side of him. To us he was kind, and he was the one who kept the routine. My nana mostly stayed in the background. My aunts Nancey or Terry, or Grandpa, watched us when my mother had to find work. My mom started over with no degree and nobody to fall back on, and she worked. That's her story to tell, in her own voice, and I hope she

does. This book is here because of her. When it came down to it, she picked us over him.

Still, I missed my papa.

When we first moved, she told me that we'd be back home in two weeks. I believed her. I was four. I don't know if she believed it too.

Crammed inside my tiny red suitcase was everything from my past life. The Mickey Mouse shirt became part of my last memory of home.

Two weeks became the rest of my life.

Compared to Mexico City, West Paterson sounded like a monastery where all the monks had taken a vow of silence. In Mexico City, sound and noise had been the texture of every day. My grandparents' house had none of it. The quiet there was on purpose. The house ran on a schedule: dinner at the same time, lights out at the same time, conversation that never wandered past what could be handled politely. It wasn't unkind, only controlled. After where I'd come from, New Jersey quiet felt close to safe.

Before long I made friends on the street, Frank and Jason, and I'd run to find them and be outside all day.

School confused me. I understood more than I could say, so I watched the other kids for cues, when to talk, when to laugh, how to stand. I quickly learned it was safer to take a room in than to announce myself. With a name like Claudio Horacio Balderas in a class of John Smiths and Erik Thomases, I stuck out. Nobody could pronounce any of it. They landed on Cloudio, which was better than some of the intentional mispronunciations, like Badder-Ass.

"What do you want to be when you grow up?" No grown-up ever asked me that. Which is good, because I would have had no answer. I couldn't have named a job if I'd tried. But I knew what I hoped to do as I got older. One word: survive. Get through the day, stay small, don't give anyone a reason to look twice.

My mother worked all the time, titleless jobs that nobody else wanted. She left early and came home tired. I saw far less of her than I had in Mexico. At night I'd climb into her bed and ask to play with her hair, and some nights she let me. The nights she did, something settled in my chest I couldn't have named. She put food on the table, kept us clean, made us safe. The thing I recall most wasn't the big sacrifices, and there were plenty of those. It was the smaller things, like the long nights she waitressed on her feet for hours, making her the kind of tired that sinks into your back and stays. On her way home, she would call to see if I was still up.

The phone would ring once, maybe twice, and I'd grab it before it woke the house. I could hear the car around her, the engine, the road.

"You still up?"

"Yeah."

"You want McDonald's?"

I always said yes. She knew the order before I gave it. Two double cheeseburgers, no mustard, no onion, fries, and a vanilla shake. She'd brought it home a hundred times. Then the car door, the bag crinkling, the smell of it before I even saw her, and her face, worn all the way down, watching me eat. A woman who had spent the entire night feeding strangers, coming home to feed her kid one more time before she slept.

That's how I knew my mother loved me.

Chris had left Mexico as a baby, so he took to New Jersey without trouble. I'd left as a four-year-old with a father to miss.

At night I thought about Horacio, not with anger, with confusion, half-expecting him to turn up one day so we could pick things back up. I didn't know how to love a man who was gone but not dead. No funeral, no grave, no explanation a child could hold. Grief has a shape when somebody dies, something to point at, a day people mark on a calendar. What I had instead was a door I kept checking, quietly,

for years, without ever admitting that's what I was doing. The grown-ups rarely spoke of him, and when they did, they mentioned him carefully, the way you handle something that might break if you name it straight.

My grandparents gave me what they had, which was steadiness, a house that stayed where it was, meals that came when they were supposed to. Not the warmth my mother gave, but reliability, and that counts for a lot when the ground has just moved. There's a wedding photograph of them walking down the aisle, Grandpa in a white dinner jacket, dark hair slicked back, grinning like he'd won something; Nana on his arm in satin, red lipstick, an armful of white roses. The two of them could have passed for movie stars. They'd aged into it gracefully — Grandpa bald by then, green-eyed, still a handsome face, a cigarette usually going somewhere in the house; Nana's high cheekbones still carrying the pretty face from that picture.

Grandpa taught high school history. At home he was a simple man, and I loved him for it. He was devoted to Wendy's, the Frosties most of all, and told me once, dead serious, that the one hole in his life was that Wendy's wouldn't sell hot dogs. He and my nana drank port wine every night out of paper cups, from a jug they kept. And ketchup was less a condiment than a way of life. It went on everything — ketchup on the ketchup — a habit I took whole.

While he taught history, he also made me interested in science. Once he took me to the railroad tracks and showed me how to lay a quarter on the rail. Then we ran off and came back after the train passed to find it flattened smooth. My mother didn't agree when she found out, but he never saw the problem.

Their dog, Abbey, became my partner at the dinner table; anything on my plate I didn't like somehow found its way to her. After dinner, we'd often play UNO, War, and checkers. Chris took up chess with him, but chess was never mine. UNO was enough.

Grandpa never talked much about his own hard childhood, but it showed in a certain toughness he expected from everyone around him.

Then there was my nana, Jan, who could catch you off guard with her gentleness. One afternoon, not long after I'd learned about cowboys and Indians in school, she mentioned she had some American Indian in her.

I burst into tears and ran to my mother. "Mom! Nana's an Indian! She's an Indian!"

From an early age, I had strong opinions about the way things should be. In my mind, cowboys were the good guys who'd ride in to save the day; Indians were the bad guys to be feared.

I also had a strong opinion about which colors belonged to Mom and my Aunt Nancey. Mom always wore red nail polish, Aunt Nancey always pink. That's just how the world worked. It had always been that way, and it followed that this rule should remain for evermore. I didn't make up those rules. Then one day, Mom and Aunt Nancey broke them. Mom came home with pink nails, and Nancey with red. I lost it. Sobbing, I insisted they had it wrong and had to put it back the way it should be. When they saw my response, they returned to the salon and changed their nails back to the "right" colors just to settle me.

I'd lost a country, a father, and a language.

Nancey, my mother's youngest sister, treated Chris and me as her own from the start. She was at the games and the matches, always in our corner. Nancey was in her early twenties when we arrived from Mexico, years before she met Charlie. She started seeing him when I was eight and married him two years later. He became my uncle. She told me not long ago that no matter how old I get, she'll always see the same little kid, and I know the one she means: the boy in the backseat too scared to get out of the car.

Aunt Terry's family had the house at Pines Lake. We'd flown to see Terry once before, in Houston, when my cousin Kevin was born and my mom was pregnant with Chris. Nancey and my grandparents all crowded into the little two-bedroom with us. The American thread never broke, even from Mexico City.

Once we landed in New Jersey for good, her house was where I made ordinary kid memories. A Halloween with the three of us in costume on the kitchen floor, tearing into the candy, Kevin as He-Man, me as a pumpkin, and Wolfie, their German Shepherd, dressed as Battle Cat. Hide-and-seek on the metal railing between the levels, where I was sure I was hidden and laughed until I cried when I sprang out and scared the one who came looking. Kevin glued to his Nintendo while the rest of us ran. A pool where somebody towed me dry while I announced I was cold, and I jumped straight back in.

What I love now is how close my mother and her sisters have become, she and Nancey and Terry, a closeness that deepened after they lost their own mother. Back then, still in those first months in New Jersey, my mom had called Papa when we landed and told him the truth. We weren't coming back. About six months later, he came anyway. He moved in with us at Grandpa and Nana's house. Even though I don't think Grandpa cared for Papa, he helped him find a job at El Torito, a Mexican restaurant. Chris wasn't even two and couldn't say the name of the restaurant. He called it el dorito and talked about the balloons. For a little while, we were a family again: Mama, Papa, Chris, and me, trying to build a life in a place that still didn't feel like home.

Papa had a way of making an ordinary day feel extraordinary. One afternoon he dressed Chris and me as Batman and Robin, though it wasn't Halloween. Mama was furious. Papa just laughed. To him, we didn't need a holiday to become superheroes. Looking back, I think he was trying to give us something no job, no country,

and no amount of uncertainty could take away: the freedom to be kids.

“Wanna race?” Papa asked me.

Instead of answering, I took off running, taking a healthy lead. I beat him. I remember feeling proud.

He held me for a minute while our breathing came back. Then he sat on the ground and cradled me in his lap.

“Claudio, I need to leave.”

I started crying.

“It will be okay,” he told me.

He looked sad when he said it. The old patterns were still there — different bars in a different country now, the same nights he didn’t come home — and he couldn’t make it work.

He went back to Mexico. It would be years before I saw him again.

A year later, my mother told us there was someone she wanted us to meet.

CHAPTER 3 ## The Man Who Didn't Have To

“A father of the fatherless... is God in his holy habitation.”
— Psalm 68:5

New Jersey, 1984

The first time he asked my mother out, she turned him down. He asked again. She gave him the same answer. But he kept coming back, week after week, until she finally saw his charm and maturity. That was how Lou Brizzi got his foot in the door of my mother's heart.

By the time Lou walked into a bar in West Paterson in 1984 to meet my mother, he was forty-three — he looked like De Niro — and had already lived a complicated life. He wanted to get the next chapter right. Mom was thirty-one, back from Mexico with two small boys and not much else, staying with her parents and taking whatever work she could find. She'd learned to be careful about who she let near her children. No charming man in a bar was going to be the exception. That's why she'd said no, and why his coming back meant he was looking for something longer than a night or two.

I was six the first time I met him. He came over to my grandparents' place, where we were living, when Nana and Grandpa invited him to dinner. Tootsie Rolls. That's all I remember about that night. Lou brought Chris and me Tootsie Rolls. A stranger walked into the house with something in his pocket for two boys who weren't even

his. This small act — treating us like we were already his own — won over our father-starved hearts.

I liked Lou. But Mom never knew how I'd stand at the window most nights watching the street, hoping Papa would come back.

It wasn't until much later that I learned the rest of Horacio's story. He'd hit a breaking point and went back to Mexico because he couldn't carry his own life and ours at the same time. I've come to believe he left so we could have something he couldn't give us. That's the generous version. It's the one I keep.

Lou was no saint, and I won't pretend he was. He had a temper that showed up at the wrong moments, and he knew that about himself. Most of it wasn't even anger; it was how he processed things he didn't like, out loud and with heat. Once a mood had him, it was hard to pull him out of it. Then he could turn around and produce a warmth so unexpected it changed the temperature of a room. Some moments were hard. He was worth it.

Once he decided you were his, that settled it. Lou was there early mornings and late nights, school conferences, wrestling matches, hospital waiting rooms, and church basements. He never kept a ledger of it, and he never talked about sacrifice. He just lived it.

Lou's upbringing explained some of it. His father sold produce. When men in suits walked into his market, his father went out back to discuss things in private. When relatives came over from Italy, Lou was the boy who lost his bed to them and slept in the attic. He carried that longer than anybody knew. Years later, during a stretch when he was going to therapy, he recalled a family Christmas and an old man yelling at his uncle about a boy who had to sleep in the attic. The temper was the Italian kind you see in the movies. It was older than any of us, and it was never about us.

He had three kids before he was twenty-five. His first wife, Judy, was a couple of years younger and fighting postpartum depression in an era that had no name for it and no help. To avoid her moods, he

stayed out late some nights, partying. The marriage couldn't hold, and the kids spent most of their time with his mother, Mag.

"No excuses," he confided in me years later. "I wasn't the best dad. My kids deserved a better one than the one they got."

Then there was Mag, who babysat Chris and me when we were boys. I saw her as the goddess of comfort. Friendly's when she was watching us. TV together on the couch. Some nights she'd fry hamburgers in butter in a pan, and I can still taste them. Whenever I lobbied for White Castle, she waved off my suggestion — she didn't like driving on the highway, and that was that. "You telling me I can't make a better hamburger right here?" she'd ask in mock offense.

A die-hard Yankees fan, she passed that passion on to Lou. If the games weren't televised, she'd listen on the radio. When she got tired, she'd take the radio to bed and listen until she fell asleep.

Lou worked IT most of his life, a lot of it on the help desk, the guy you call when the thing won't work. He didn't stop until he was eighty-two. Never wealthy, Lou always angled for a second income to help pay the bills. For a while he had a booth at the Union Flea Market, called Lew's, a different spelling of his own name. I hated every Saturday I spent working it, but nobody asked. Left alone on Sundays, he watched his games: the Yankees in the summer, the Giants in the fall. That was the whole vice.

People asked Lou why he decided to take on somebody else's two boys. He never dressed up the answer.

"Have you seen their mother? She's drop-dead gorgeous. Beautiful and ten years younger than me. You do the math."

That was the honest start of it. The staying part he never explained.

Lou and Mom married at Pines Lake, in Wayne, New Jersey, where Aunt Terry's family lived, the same place the Halloween candy hit the kitchen floor. Around the time Lou came into our lives,

we left West Paterson for a house of our own in Woodridge. That was the home of my grade-school years, before Ramsey.

He adopted us when I was eight. The paperwork had taken years. International adoption in the eighties crawled and required everything in triplicate. Lou wasn't a patient man by nature, but he was patient in practice. He made the trips, sat in the offices, signed what they put in front of him, and waited for the next form.

When the time came to change our names, my mother told me Grandpa wanted to ask me something. We went down to the basement of the Woodridge house, surrounded by wood paneling, brown shag carpet, and the cool stale smell of basement air. Grandpa Bob sat me down and got to the point the way he always did.

"Change your first name to Robert," he said. "Rob. And I'll give you a hundred dollars."

I was eight. A hundred dollars was a fortune. I didn't even have to think about it.

"Okay," I said.

Then I asked him something he hadn't planned for.

"Can my middle name be Lou?"

Nobody had suggested it. I just wanted to carry it. That day Claudio Horacio Balderas became Robert Louis Brizzi. I had carried one father's name in the middle of mine my whole life. Now I would carry the other's. I've never once wished it back.

When I was six, Lou taught me to swim by carrying me to the edge of the pool and throwing me in. I came up coughing and furious, my arms going the way arms go when a body fights drowning. I reached the wall and pulled myself out. Lou stood there watching, not laughing, just paying attention the way a man does when he's handed his kid something he'll need. He didn't make a speech. I got back in the water the next time, and the time after that.

Some dads spend their weekends chasing hobbies like golf, manicuring their lawns, or sleeping on the couch. Not Lou. His

whole hobby was us. Saturday mornings at the batting cages in Woodridge, his hands on my shoulders fixing my stance, not because I was ever going to play ball but because he believed doing a thing right was a habit worth building. Soccer fields in the New Jersey cold, Lou on the sideline in a coat he didn't need to be wearing, watching me play a sport I was actually pretty good at. I took it all for granted, the way a child is supposed to do with childhood.

Lou and my mother decided early that Chris and I would be raised in church. It wasn't up for discussion. Sunday mornings, confirmation, and at thirteen I chose God and accepted Him into my heart. That part wasn't handed to me by the adults around me. It was mine — the first real decision I ever made for myself besides taking Lou as my middle name. My decision to follow Christ was real. I meant it. I'd lose the thread of it for a long time, the drinking years, California, the stretch when I was too busy performing life to remember what mine was built on. I left my faith, but it waited for me to return.

We moved to Ramsey when I was in sixth grade. Bigger house, new school, a town where the kids had known each other since before I showed up, and I came in as the new boy with dark olive skin and features that didn't match the rest of Bergen County.

At lunch I sat at the end of the table, in the back corner, trying to be invisible and still wanting to be let in. It wasn't long before they started in on me.

But I had Lou, who understood that a boy who comes home quiet in the wrong way doesn't need to be interrogated, he needs someone there. He couldn't fix school for me. He was just home when I got there, and that turned out to be enough.

The school paired me with a buddy to show me around those first weeks, a kid everybody called Whitey. We didn't get close then — that year I was mostly on my own. But by high school, Whitey had become one of my best friends, and all these years later, he still is.

When I got into Miami of Ohio, part of me hoped Whitey would land there too, an easy way to carry the friendship forward. He chose Bates College, up in Maine. I'd wanted a next chapter; what we got was a fork in the road.

And there was my neighbor Rich, a fellow member of the school's wrestling team. We were always into something together. In high school he turned himself into an overachiever at it — the way he was at everything he touched.

The year I left for college my mother told him she was done. He didn't take it well. He wanted the unit held together — that was the thing he had built, and he wasn't ready to watch it come apart.

My mother and Lou divorced in 1996, the year I turned eighteen. The divorce handed him an easy way out and every social permission to take it. We were grown, or close to it, and the marriage that had tied him to us was finished. He could have put the frustration and the guilt on Chris and me and gone. He never did. We were never in question, a plain fact he never bothered to announce: we were his, and that didn't come undone because the marriage had. The first time he chose us, it was a handful of Tootsie Rolls at my grandparents' dinner table. This time it was a divorce he could have walked away from clean, yet he stayed. The same decision, made twelve years apart.

I get it now. I didn't back then. I see it every day at work — in the room with a family around a bed, watching some grown son or daughter hold a hand that's already going cool, trying to figure out what thirty years of somebody just being there actually meant. For me, it started on a Saturday. With a bucket of baseballs.

CHAPTER 4 ## Chosen

*“I have called thee by thy name; thou art mine.” — Isaiah
43:1*

New Jersey, 1986

Overnight, I gained a big sister and two big brothers I hadn't even known to hope for. Lou had three children of his own long before he ever met my mother: Jon, Lisa, and Joel, thirteen to seventeen years older than me and grown or nearly grown by the time he met her. When he chose us, we inherited his existing family. Chris and I were thrilled. We felt blessed. His other children didn't have to accept us, though. They already had their own lives and never expected they'd need to make room for two boys from Mexico City who showed up attached to their father's new marriage. But they did. They treated us like brothers.

It could not have been easy for them. Their dad spent Saturdays hitting fly balls to me and driving me to every wrestling match. They hadn't grown up with an attentive, hands-on dad, so they had every reason to resent this new version of their dad who seemed to be doing it all right. Instead of punishing me or Chris, they folded us in.

Lisa served as our babysitter when we were not the easiest to look after. She did it without making it out to be a sacrifice. She still hosts Thanksgiving every year, and keeps the table set the way our nana did. You'll meet her again later, at that table.

Joel treated us well from the start. Steady. He was there, and didn't need credit for it. Whatever Chris and I needed growing up, Joel jumped in to help. The jokester of the family, Joel's the class clown who never really grew out of it. And I hope he never does.

He's also the family's historian, the one who remembers all the stories about me, from when I spoke little English and my mom started dating Lou. He still tells them. There's the night at a Chinese restaurant when somebody asked what I wanted to eat and I said, with total confidence, "Taco." On the ferry from New Jersey to New York, the family car already rolling up the ramp onto the boat, and me asking hopefully whether we could put the car on the boat. All these years later Joel will still drop either one into a conversation just to watch me brace for it. That's its own kind of love, the teasing you only get once you're truly in.

Jon was already out of the house by the time Chris and I arrived, so he wasn't around much in those early years. He and I found each other later, through wrestling. He married Holly, her kids wrestled, I had wrestled, and that was the bridge. There is a shorthand between wrestling people. You don't have to explain the weight cuts, or the losing, or what it takes to walk back out for the next period. Jon understood it without my having to say it. He is also one of the quietest overachievers I know. He started out at Juniata College getting C's and finished as a partner at a major software company. More reserved than the rest of us, Jon is kind all the way through. His story rhymes with Chris's, the underdog who becomes the success. Lou's people don't stay down.

I remember the three of us driving down to Philadelphia for a Giants game once, all of us grown men by then. No occasion, just an excuse to be together. That was Lou's way, even beyond childhood: make a regular Sunday feel like it mattered.

The moment I felt closest to Jon came years later, both of us grown. He was successful by then, getting close to retirement. I was

up in New Jersey for a work training, and I took an hour-and-a-half Uber ride just to go see him. We ended up walking, the two of us, and he told me about a guy he'd mentored at his company, how grateful the man was for the chance, and what it had done for his whole family. The way Jon told it, the thing he was proud of wasn't the success. It was having been of use to somebody. That was a side of him I'd only seen in pieces. That day I got the whole of it.

That's the part that still gets me. Jon, Lisa, and Joel could have kept us at the edge of the family, at a small distance that never quite closes. They never drew that line. We were siblings. We still are.

We lived on Woodridge Street, and Domino's was our pizza. Back then they ran the promise: thirty minutes or it's free. What they didn't account for was that our town had a Woodridge Street and a Woodridge Avenue, and the driver went to the Avenue every single time. He'd turn up at our door late and apologizing, and he'd hand us the pizza and our money back. Free Domino's, over and over, because a guy couldn't tell a street from an avenue. Chris and I were sure we'd beaten the system.

Claudio and Rob

I wasn't given to Lou. I chose him.

It happened at night, when he was tucking me in. He'd pulled the blanket up to my chin the way he always did, his hand still resting on it, about to say goodnight. The room was dark except for the hall light coming through the cracked door. I'd been holding the question all day, and in the dark it finally came loose.

"Can I call you Dad?"

For a second he didn't say anything. Then I watched his eyes fill. I had never seen him tear up, not once. But there it was.

"Yes," he said. "Of course, son."

He didn't make a thing of it. He finished tucking me in the way he had every other night, except now I had a word for him I hadn't had a minute before.

Choosing one father didn't erase the other. A parent who loses a child can't set another one in the empty spot and call it even. It doesn't run the other way either. I had chosen Lou, and I meant it. But I still had room inside my heart with Horacio's name on the door.

For years I felt guilty about Horacio. I knew, the way a kid knows things without being told, what losing me had done to him. Some part of me decided it was my fault, as if I were the one who had done the leaving. I was four. Nothing about the decision to leave had been mine. The guilt didn't care. It stayed anyway.

When they changed my name, that one landed harder. Claudio became Robert Brizzi. On paper it was clean and it was right. I know that now. Back then it felt like a correction, like the old name had been a mistake somebody was fixing, and I was the mistake.

School was where I felt it the most. Second grade, Woodridge. I'd write Claudio at the top of my homework without thinking, my hand moving the way it always had, and Mrs. Locke would catch it. She was kind about it, every time.

"Honey," she'd say, setting the paper back on my desk, tapping the top corner with one finger. "Remember? We write Robert now."

I'd take my eraser and rub the name out until the paper went soft and gray, and print the new one in the bald spot I'd left. Robert. Then I'd hand it back, and she'd smile like we'd fixed something together. It didn't feel fixed. It felt like erasing me.

Years later, I went out for the football team. Trying out meant a physical, and the physical meant turning in a copy of my birth certificate. I hadn't looked at mine in years.

It was the end of summer. We were lined up waiting our turn, and I was still the shy one. The kid next to me reached over and took the paper out of my hand.

“Let me see that.”

He read it. Then he said the word out loud, printed plain for anyone standing close enough to hear. “Adopted.”

He had questions after that. So you don’t have a real dad?

“Yes, I do,” I said.

I went home wrecked and told my father.

He didn’t give me a speech. He got the white-out and painted over the word, let it dry, and ran a fresh photocopy, and the thing they’d been using on me was gone. He wasn’t hiding the truth — everyone who mattered already knew it. He was lifting a weight off a kid who wasn’t ready to carry it. That was how my parents handled the adoption all along. Not a secret. A shield. Somebody was hurting their son, and Lou fixed the part he could reach.

There was one thing they couldn’t change, and I held onto it. Brizzi still started with a B. When the teacher lined us up alphabetically, I landed near the front, right about where Balderas used to put me. My country was gone. My first father was gone. My name was gone. But I still stood in the same place in that line, and some mornings that one small thing was the only proof I had that any part of the old me had made the trip.

CHAPTER 5 ## The Man Who Raised Me

“Let us not love in word, neither in tongue; but in deed and in truth.” — 1 John 3:18

New Jersey, 1985

I carried his name before I understood what was behind it. What Lou taught me about being a man came down to a few things, none of them speeches.

Don’t complain. Don’t play the victim. Show up.

He never sat me down and said those words. Instead, he lived them out loud in front of me every day until they became part of who I am.

Where I saw it most was the wrestling tournaments upstate. Dad drove me up into New York weekend after weekend, however far the bracket took us. He didn’t talk about the miles, the early start, or that he had worked the night before. He just got in the car, because his kid was wrestling and that was where he was supposed to be.

The drives were endless, even for me, and I wasn’t driving. Cooperstown. New York City. Albany, to see the Double-A Yankees. Lehigh, out in Pennsylvania. Philadelphia, where he took Jon and me to a Giants–Eagles game. Somebody in the rows below us had a sign: LT CHOOSES COKE OVER PEPSI. Lawrence Taylor was the best defensive player in football and by then everyone knew about the cocaine, so his addiction had become public sport. Lou went down and took the sign, and it almost started a fight. I was a kid; I

thought it was about football. It took me years to wonder whether it was about something else — whether some part of him just couldn't watch a stadium laugh at a man for the thing that was eating him.

When he coached baseball, the Foxes and the Falcons, he was harder on me than anyone else. He'd take me to the field where he would hit me a hundred balls, then a hundred more. At the batting cages, he fed the machine until my hands were raw from gripping the bat. He never let me quit because it hurt. *Stay in the box. Take the next pitch.* That was the lesson under the lesson.

Chris and Dad shared a phrase between them. After the big moments, like something at school, a hard-won wrestling match, or a new job, they would whisper to each other: *Hey Dad, we made it.*

I had my own version of that feeling in that car coming home from upstate, the quiet after a long day, the two of us, the feeling that we had done the thing together. That was Lou's idea of love. Not announced. Earned, together. And when he was proud of me, he rarely said so. He'd give me a small smile and a look. His expression said all of it.

He didn't connect with me only on the big things. One time I asked for White Castle, and the nearest one was an hour away. He drove me. An hour there for a sack of little burgers, because his kid had a taste for them. When I needed a root canal out at college in Ohio, he drove ten hours to take me to the dentist and ten hours back. A full day of driving, for a dentist's chair. In both pleasure and pain, Dad was there.

And once, it was far bigger than a tournament, a sack of burgers, or a dentist's chair. In college in Ohio I went down into something I couldn't explain, and he drove ten hours to sit across a table from me. He came the way he always had, except this time it wasn't for a game. He came because he loved me.

Somewhere on that drive, just the two of us in the car, I said it for the first time.

“Dad, thank you for saving my life.”

“You saved mine.”

Neither of us said anything else. We would trade those same two lines maybe ten more times over the years. His answer never changed.

Then there was the time I lived in West Palm Beach. By then, I wasn't a kid anymore. I was a grown man, deep in addiction, and out of options. Dad flew down and pulled me, his dying son, out of it. He didn't shame me. He came one more time, when coming meant saving my life.

I broke down in front of him once. I don't remember anymore what had pushed me there. I let him see me like that because I trusted him. He didn't tell me to pull it together. He let me get it out, and then he looked at me and said it plain.

“I love you as much as I love my own kids.”

For as long as I could remember I'd carried a quiet question, whether I was really his, whether being chosen was the same as belonging. He answered it in one sentence. As much as his own. He didn't soften it. I believed him.

It took me years to see what he had handed me. I make my living showing up. I walk into rooms other people can't bring themselves to enter, and I stay, even when I don't know what to say. But I know how to be there, and I learned it from a man who drove me up to tournaments in upstate New York, and an hour out of his way for White Castle because I asked. Everything I do at a bedside, I first learned in his car.

PART TWO

THE MAT

Love came free at home. Everywhere else, I thought you had to win it.

CHAPTER 6 ## The Wrestler

“And Jacob was left alone; and there wrestled a man with him until the breaking of the day.” — Genesis 32:24

Before the mat, there was the lunch table. Sixth grade in Ramsey, and I was the new kid with the wrong name and dark skin in a town that had almost none of either. The classroom was one room and the cafeteria was another, and the cafeteria I could not win.

There was a table I sat at every day, and the kids at it had a thing they said about me. Brizzi beats off. They would say it and squirt mayonnaise across the table to go with it, a little performance, every day, for the rest of the table to laugh at. I didn't even know what it meant. I knew it was about me, I knew it was filthy, and I knew the laughing was at me. That was enough.

And I kept sitting with them. That's the part I sit with now. Every day they did it, and every day I carried my tray back to the same seat. I didn't move tables. I didn't eat alone. Getting picked on by them felt better than having no one, and in a town where friends didn't come easy, that was the table. So I sat down and took it.

Kris and Kyle were twin brothers, the most popular kids in the grade, and they sat there too, and they never once joined in. They didn't stop it. They just left me alone, and being left alone by the

popular kids was as close to safe as that room got. I remembered their names for thirty years. I never remembered the ones who did it.

It went on the rest of middle school. By the end the joke had moved into ink. Somebody wrote have fun chokin' the chicken in my yearbook, the book you're supposed to keep.

I crossed it out before my mom could see it. That is the part that tells you who I already was. She had carried two boys out of one country and built us a life in another with no degree and no one to catch her. I wasn't going to hand her this too. So I took a pen to my own yearbook and scratched the line out, alone, so she would never have to feel it. I was fourteen. I didn't have the word for it yet. I was already a caretaker.

I couldn't fix the cafeteria. But there was one place in that town where nobody got to rank me, where there was no table and no lineup and no committee deciding what I was worth. One body against one body, and whatever I'd been handed, I got to settle it myself.

The first place I had to learn to show up for myself, with Lou watching from the stands, was a wrestling mat. I was twelve when wrestling first came up, and it came up between Charlie and my dad. The two of them talked it over before anybody said a word to me. It wasn't a read on any talent. I didn't have any. I was awkward, undersized, the kid picked somewhere in the middle in gym class, not last, which would've been a story, just middle. It was a hunch, the way people point a kid at something because nothing else has stuck.

Charlie was Aunt Nancey's husband, and a room got lighter the moment he walked into it. He laughed easily. He looked at you, even when you were a kid, like what you were saying was the most interesting thing he'd heard all day. He loved my aunt, and she loved him. I talked to Nancey recently and she didn't dress it up: there will never be another man like Charlie. She hasn't dated in years.

Charlie was the one who came into our basement and taught us the beginning: stance, balance, top, bottom, how to keep moving when another person was trying to hold you down.

Before Charlie ever came over to make his case to Chris and me, my dad sat me down and asked if it was something I wanted to do. He didn't sign me up. He asked. Then he said, we'll try it, the way he said that about a lot of things, not with any heat, just the quiet of a man who figured most things give way to persistence. So I went.

Charlie introduced us to wrestling. Lou made sure we stayed with it. Four nights a week he drove an hour each way to The Edge Wrestling Club so Chris and I could get extra practice. He never complained about the miles, the gas, or the late nights. He simply believed we were worth the investment.

Before any championships or newspaper headlines, he took me to the Bergen County Tournament. Forty-eight teams filled the gym, and he was thrilled when a Ramsey wrestler made it into the second round.

"Maybe someday you could win a match here," he told me.

That was Lou. He didn't make grand speeches. He showed his love in carpools, tournament weekends, church on Sundays, and thousands of hours sitting beside wrestling mats.

Years later, I returned to that same tournament and left as Bergen County champion.

The wrestling room ran warmer than the rest of the building. Years of work had soaked into the mats and the walls, and it hit me at the door, rubber and sweat and something dingy underneath. I loved that room. Not because it was comfortable. Because it was the one place I didn't have to figure out who to be. I just had to work, and work I understood.

Wrestling is the loneliest sport there is. You step on the mat and nobody can help you. No subs, no timeouts that matter. You and him

and six minutes and whatever you brought that week. If you hadn't put the work in, it showed. If you were afraid, it showed.

Practice was the same every day. Running first, then drills, shots, sprawls, stand-ups, until the moves lived below thinking. My legs knew when to change levels; my hands knew where to find a wrist. Then Coach called live and it was full speed. Drop into stance, knees bent, hands out, eyes between his shoulders and hips. The whistle, and we'd close, foreheads together, hands fighting for position, the work happening in adjustments too small to read from the bleachers. On the mat you felt all of it, every shift of weight, every half-second of hesitation. You couldn't hide. Everywhere else I could build the version of myself the room wanted. Not there.

The mental game was the real opponent. Six minutes stretched forever while your lungs burned and your mind offered every excuse to quit. Fear rode right there with you, fear of getting taken down in front of everyone, fear of gassing out. The fear didn't go anywhere. I breathed, changed levels, kept my hands ready. When my body wanted to quit, I told it no. Stay. Fight the wrist. Explode up. The mat didn't care about my story or the questions inside me. It only cared that I kept showing up.

Making weight was its own war inside the bigger one. I dropped pounds fast, sweating in trash bags, spitting into cups, skipping meals, anything to hit the number. The scale ruled everything. Mornings I stepped on it with my heart in my throat, willing it down. Hunger gnawed at me all the time. My head went foggy, my temper short, my thoughts mean. One extra bite and I'd feel I had failed the team, failed myself, failed the work we all put in. Part of me was proud of the discipline. Part of me was ashamed of what I'd do to my body to prove I belonged. After weigh-ins the relief crashed in and I'd binge hard, then hate myself for it. Cutting weight taught me I could choose the harder thing. It also showed me a line I would cross years later with worse things than food.

My first varsity match, freshman year, didn't go how I'd planned. The whistle blew and the kid shot a double-leg before I'd finished setting my feet: dropped his level, got in under my hips, wrapped both my legs and locked his hands. There's no style to it. It just takes your legs out from under you. I saw it coming and couldn't stop it. He drove through me, my back hit the mat, and his weight came down across my chest. I heard the ref's hand slap the mat once. Then it was over. Nineteen seconds, start to finish.

I lay there a second looking up at the gym lights in the rafters, the crowd noise coming back in around me, something flat settling in my stomach. I got up. Shook his hand. Walked back to the corner. Lou was in the stands. He said nothing. He just held my eyes and gave me the smallest nod, the one that meant we go back to work.

He was always in the stands. He almost never missed a match in four years of high school, not that nineteen-second one, not the close ones that went wrong, not the good ones once the work started showing. Third row, usually. Arms crossed, not in judgment, in attention, or the camcorder up and running. Wrestling was the only thing he ever taped, the only reason he owned the thing. My mother and Aunt Nancey were there too. Every match. And after every weigh-in, when I had starved myself down to the number for days, my mom was there with Wendy's chicken sandwiches, ready the second I made weight. She always seemed to know what a thing had cost me, and she always had the food waiting. That was how she loved you. She fed you.

Freshman year I finished two and four. That nineteen-second pin was one of the losses.

The victories came later, and they were never only about wrestling. Somewhere along the way I had learned that success was how I gained acceptance. If I kept winning, people would value me. If I stopped, I feared they might not.

For years I thought wrestling was making me into someone. Looking back, I realize it was also teaching me something dangerous. I was beginning to believe that winning was who I was.

Cooperstown

Cooperstown, New York, 1991

I was twelve. A quarter to eight on a Saturday morning, and Dad was in my doorway, already dressed, keys in his hand.

“You want to take a ride?”

“Where are we going?”

“It’s a surprise.”

I rubbed my eyes and said yes.

We got in the car and he drove. An hour in, I didn’t ask. Two hours in, I did.

“Dad. Where are we going?”

He looked over, smiling a little. “Cooperstown.”

It was five hours from our house, the Baseball Hall of Fame, and he kept driving like it was nothing.

We got there a little after one and walked up together. Inside it was dim and cool, glass cases everywhere, bats and gloves and jerseys worn by men I’d only ever seen on television. Dad walked me through it case by case, in no hurry. He stopped at a baseball.

“That’s a ball from Babe Ruth.”

We stood there a long time, both of us looking at it.

We got back in the car a little before five, and I was asleep before long. When I woke up we were home. Ten hours of driving for a building full of gloves and a ball Babe Ruth once touched. He never said why.

Dave Meyer

The projections had Dave Meyer at quarterback, until a kid named Michael Vick showed up.

But Dave's story began for me at church, the other place, besides wrestling, where Lou made sure Chris and I went. Lou believed boys needed structure. Church taught us who we were supposed to become. Wrestling taught us what it would cost.

That was where I met Dave.

Dave seemed to possess naturally what I was fighting to earn. He was confident, athletic, grounded in his faith, and accepted wherever he went. Yet he never made me prove I belonged beside him.

Junior prom was the first warning. Someone asked what I wanted to drink. I knew my parents drank Absolut Citron, so I answered confidently. "Don't mix it. Just bring the fifth."

Two hours later, I was throwing up in the limousine. Four hours later, my friends carried me into prom like *Weekend at Bernie's*.

The principal called my mother. I was suspended, and my first concern was whether I would remain captain of the wrestling team.

Even then, I cared more about protecting the image than understanding what had happened.

Dave's football plans eventually changed. His character did not. Mine was beginning to.

Dave went on to play in the NFL, then became a missionary in China, and years later we found our way back to each other. He's the one who wrote the afterword to this book. That tells you who he is.

CHAPTER 7 ## What the Mat Left

“And every man that striveth for the mastery is temperate in all things.” — 1 Corinthians 9:25

Ramsey, New Jersey, 1993

Sophomore Year: The Turn

Freshman year I lost more than I won. Early sophomore season I drew the top seed in a tournament, a kid everyone knew would win, the kid I was supposed to be a warm-up for. Something happened I still can't fully explain. I wasn't afraid of him. The fear that had been the ground note of every match since that first pin just wasn't there. What was there was anger, not at him, at the idea that I was supposed to lose. I beat him. Ugly, grinding, the full three periods. But I won it. Afterward Lou didn't say much. A hand on my shoulder. In his language it meant: I always knew this was in you.

I won the District at 119 in 1994, seeded fifth of the eight in the bracket, expected to place nowhere near the top. The recognition came fast after that. One afternoon Mr. Molino pulled me out of class, and I walked down the hall sure I was in trouble, running through everything I might have done. Instead he told me I'd been named Athlete of the Month for Ramsey High School. They put my name on the billboard in front of the school for the whole month, where the entire town of Ramsey could read it. They painted it on the

wall in the old gym too, and I was the first sophomore they had ever done that for.

I couldn't take any of it in. The gap between who everyone suddenly said I was and who I knew myself to be was too wide to cross. The achievement was real. The sense that I had earned it wasn't there, and it wouldn't be for years. I'd feel the same thing later, on MTV with cameras pointed at me, the same quiet question running underneath it all: who am I to be anybody? It would take a long time, and losing nearly everything, before I could stand in a room and believe I belonged in it.

Junior Year

Junior year I cut nineteen pounds the week of the tournament, then binged so hard after weigh-ins that I threw up twice on the mat during a match against a guy who had two wins over me. The ref stopped it. Greeny, Coach Greenshields, got a towel, cleaned me up, sent me back out. I won the match and the tournament — my second straight District title.

That season in Regions I drew a kid who almost never lost, a Bergen County name everyone knew, dominant and smart, the kind who wins because he rarely makes a mistake. Quarterfinals, he was the two seed, I was the seven. Six minutes. Ten seconds left, I was down 6–5. He let me up, experienced guys do that with a lead, sure they can ride it out on their feet. He shouldn't have. Three seconds on the clock I shot a single-leg, dropped low and took his lead leg and pulled it tight to my chest, my arms there before my brain caught up. He was standing on one foot. His balance was gone. Takedown, 7–6, final. The paper the next day: "Late Takedown Keeps Ramsey's Brizzi Going."

I won my semi, lost a close one in the finals, still went to States. Finished 18–4. After that match Lou sat with me while I caught my breath and the bracket moved on without us.

“I’m proud of you, son.”

He knew what it had taken to get there. He wasn’t making it into anything bigger than it was; he was just enjoying it with me. I nodded. That was enough for both of us.

Charlie

I was in middle school when I got the news about Charlie. He and Nancey had separated and he’d drifted somewhere harder to reach. The disease had him, the same one that had Papa, and the same one that came for me a decade later, though I didn’t know that yet. My dad was the one who went and got him, found him alone in his apartment the way you find someone who’s stopped being able to take care of himself. Charlie died about four years after that. I never knew if he got sober in there. He felt sober to me when I saw him — but a kid reads what he wants to read, and to this day I can’t tell you whether those last years were clean or whether the disease had just gone quiet.

I loved him, and that’s hard to explain to people who think grief needs proximity. I hadn’t talked to him in years. I was sixteen, buried in wrestling and school. But I’d loved him, and when he died something opened in me I didn’t have a name for. Nobody validated it. He was the first person I loved who died. I’d lost Papa years before, but there was no funeral, nothing to stand in front of. Papa was gone and still alive somewhere. Charlie was gone.

What stays with me now: Lou walked into that apartment before he ever walked into mine. When he came for me in West Palm Beach years later and found me in the dark, it wasn’t his first time doing it. He’d already gone into a room where someone he loved was losing,

and it hadn't been enough. He came for me anyway, knowing how it can end.

Senior Year: County Champion

Senior year I won the District again, three straight years on that wall, and came into the Counties as the top seed at 130. My brother Chris was a freshman at 103. In the sauna, cutting weight together, we'd said it would be something if we ever shared an article. Chris upset the number-one seed to make the semis. The paper ran it: "Ramsey's Brizzi Brothers are Double Trouble." Dad was beaming.

I won the semis and the final 15-7, county champion at seventeen. My name on the wall again. Seventeen. I wouldn't understand that number for another thirty years.

I hurt my ankle in Regions, wasn't myself in the semis, lost. I wrestled through it for third, won that match, and advanced to States. I finished high school 81-18. From two wins and four losses as a freshman to a school record.

Chris is more than the records. He went 120-4, three county titles, two region titles, three district titles, placed at States three times, took second at freestyle nationals in Fargo. The kid the school wanted to hold back in third grade rewrote every record at Ramsey High I'd set. Every one.

The hazel-eyed baby my mother carried out of Mexico is silver-haired now, a father himself, the light skin and the easy grin still intact. He's complicated. Smart. Polished and strategic, an over-achiever in the true sense. And still, the first thing anyone says about him is that he's kind. Quietly, consistently kind. He's my best friend. We took different paths and processed the same childhood differently, but there's nobody I'd rather have call me on Christmas morning, nobody I'd rather have beside me at a graveside. Lou built

us both, differently, and never compared us. He showed up for Chris's records and my county title with the same pride.

The Lesson and The Exception

Coach Albersi met me before school to run the track. He invested in me. At the year-end gathering he said, Brizzi went down a legend. But when I was struggling, he wasn't around much. When I excelled, everyone wanted to be attached to it.

Lou was the exception. Through all of it, the nineteen seconds, the weight cuts, the throwing up, the bad ankle, the losses that hurt more than the wins, he was there. Not because I was becoming a legend. Because I was his son.

One moment at the Counties: I was about to wrestle for the title and my Walkman got stolen. I needed it to warm up. Lou didn't lecture me. He drove to Best Buy and bought me a new one. Years later I said, Dad, you always did whatever I asked. He paused the way he paused before something true. Rob. There were times that was the last twenty dollars I had in my pocket. And I gave it to you. No resentment. Just a fact. I didn't know what to say. I still don't.

When I threw up in a match, he didn't see weakness. When I got pinned in nineteen seconds, he didn't see failure. He saw his kid. He was in the third row for all of it, and I never once asked what it had cost him to be there.

The Marks

The wrestling years left marks I still feel. For a long time my body didn't feel like my own. It was something to manage, a number to beat, proof I deserved my place. Food stayed complicated, some meals were cheat meals, others I ate lean. When life felt out of control, drop the pounds was still the first thought that came back. The same drive that cut nineteen pounds to make weight later went

looking for other ways to numb everything. It took years to make peace with my body, and it wasn't discipline that got me there. It was my mother's quiet meals. Some days I still have to choose that peace on purpose. It gets easier every year.

CHAPTER 8 ## The Suit

*“Drudgery is the touchstone of character.” — Oswald
Chambers*

Ramsey, New Jersey, 1993

A recruiter looked at my father across a desk and told him to dye the gray out of his hair. Nobody would hire him otherwise. He went home and did it, and never said a word about it. I understood the price only later, when the money got tight. By then he was in his early fifties and we were living in Ramsey. I was in high school — old enough to notice tension, too young to know its price.

From the outside our life looked stable. A house. Cars in the driveway. Dinner on the table, wrestling practice, the bills paid, the routine holding. I didn’t see how much of it was held up by him getting out of bed every morning.

He had a good job. Good enough that the lights stayed on, the mortgage got paid, and we had the things kids never stop to think about — shoes, gas, food, wrestling lessons. Then he got laid off.

Nobody sat me down and explained it. No family meeting, no speech, no panic I can remember. That wasn’t him. But I felt it. The house got quieter. My mother’s voice got softer. Adults paused half a second too long before answering simple questions. My dad got more focused, not less. Deliberate. Like a switch had been thrown and every move mattered now.

He'd taken on a family that didn't start with him. A wife who waited tables. Two boys who weren't his by blood. A mortgage, car payments, credit card debt. He never acted like any of it was somebody else's problem. He owned all of it.

The recruiter had put it to him straight, the way you tell a man something for his own good. You want a real shot, he said, you've got to dye the gray. They're going to look at you and see an old man. A grown man, a husband, a father, told he had to look younger than he was to be worth a chance. That detail has never left me.

Every day he put on a suit. Every single day, even when there was no interview on the calendar, nowhere definite to go. He shaved, tied the tie, polished his shoes, and walked out the door like a man with somewhere to be. He treated looking for work as work.

I don't know how many interviews there were. In my memory it felt endless — double digits at least. Enough that rejection could have turned personal. Enough that another man might have come home bitter, or loud, or ashamed. He never did. The mortgage still came due. So did the credit cards. But he never made us feel like we were too expensive to raise. Wrestling lessons never felt selfish. We never felt guilty for needing rides, or food, or hope.

They told him no, and the next morning he knotted the tie again. He wasn't loud about what he carried. He carried it. Eventually he found work. A man like that was never going to stay down.

I can still see him at the front door. Dyed hair, pressed shirt, tie pulled tight, shoes shined. That's what he did while he waited. He kept showing up.

CHAPTER 9 ## They'll Teach You

*“A good name is rather to be chosen than great riches.” —
Proverbs 22:1*

New York, 1997

The summer I was nineteen, between semesters at Miami and working construction, my dad called and said he got me a job. Auditing. I said, auditing? Dad, I haven't taken an accounting class yet. He said, they'll teach you.

I won't use the name of the guy who hired me. Very Italian name, one of those guys with a nickname like Mickey Marbles or Paulie the Piece. Bad toupee, drove a Buick. The office wasn't an office, it was a back room with one other person in it, an Italian girl named Felicia. He tells me I'll be driving the five boroughs auditing the books for a trade union. Nineteen years old, fake glasses, a suit that didn't quite fit, about to walk into union offices in Harlem, Brooklyn, and Manhattan pretending to know what I was looking at.

First they sent me out with a guy named Sal to train me. Everywhere we went, people knew him. Hey Sal, what's up Sal, big handshakes, big smiles. Three days of that, and in three days Sal didn't teach me one thing. Not what to look for, not what auditing even meant, not a single page. Then he told me he had to get out of the area. His exact words. I was nineteen. I didn't know what that meant. I still don't. But Sal was gone, and now it was just me.

They'd sit me down with these giant ledgers and I'd flip pages like I knew what I was doing. They were always nice about it. You want coffee, cake, donuts? I'd say no, flip pages for an hour, leave.

After a few weeks the boss calls and says I'm leaving too early. I said, I don't know what I'm doing, I don't know what I'm looking at. He said — I'll never forget it — it doesn't matter, I get paid by the hour, just sit in there and punch numbers into the calculator. That's when it landed. Whatever this was, it wasn't accounting. I left him a note and went back to construction. Didn't even quit in person.

That job came out of my dad's world — a conversation at a bar in Mahwah, a handshake, a phone call. He had no idea what the job actually was. Neither did I, until I was inside it: his nineteen-year-old son on somebody's payroll, driving the five boroughs in fake glasses, pretending to audit books nobody wanted audited.

After the divorce he lived in Mahwah. He'd go out, have a drink, talk to people. He could sit next to a stranger and walk out with a new friend and a business opportunity. Not scheming. Just how he worked.

That was the world I grew up inside. Outside it, my dad knew everybody. Not the way people say that at networking events. He actually did — the people you'd expect and the ones you wouldn't. His world had more layers than I understood as a kid. Lou didn't explain himself. He just lived it, and every so often you'd catch a glimpse and think: who is my father?

When I was about seven he took me to visit friends of his somewhere in Jersey. Nice house. Long hair, laid back, growing what they called funny tobacco out back. Inside, one of them stood at the wall polishing something — a round flat thing in a frame — working a cloth over it slow and careful, proud of it. I just knew it was shiny and gold.

Home that night, my mom asked how it went. I told her about the nice guys shining their gold records.

She stopped what she was doing and looked at me. “You know who that is, right?”

I shook my head.

“That’s the Rascals.” When that didn’t land, she tried again. “You know ‘It’s a Beautiful Morning’? ‘Groovin’?”

I had no idea. I was seven. They were my dad’s friends with shiny things on the wall.

But that was Lou. The Rascals — Rock and Roll Hall of Famers, one of the biggest bands of the sixties — were his buddies. They came to his eightieth birthday.

Years later we’re at my sister Lisa’s place in Sarasota, walking into breakfast at Another Broken Egg, and my dad spots a guy outside. His face lights up. Dickie V! The guy turns, and it’s Dick Vitale — the actual Dick Vitale. They’d gone to high school together in Jersey, and my dad had been telling me about it for years. Me and Dickie V. I’d nod the way you nod at a man who also swore the lawn was being handled by a goat. Then one morning there’s Dickie V himself, turning around at the sound of my father’s voice and lighting up right back at him.

That was Lou. He could not help mentioning the people he knew — the Rascals, Dickie V, a guy from the union hall — all in the same breath and the same easy tone. It should have been insufferable. It wasn’t, and the reason is simple: every name was true. He never inflated a thing, and that was the funny part. He’d really been there for all of it, and he name-dropped the way a kid spreads out his baseball cards — not to impress you, just tickled you were finally looking.

There’s one story I only heard a couple of years ago, from someone close to the family I won’t name. He was a teenager then, and my dad used to put odd jobs his way, errands, cash in his pocket. One day an acquaintance of my dad’s pulled up outside his house and told him to get in the car. A kid at school had been picking on the

man's daughter, calling her fat. He drove him there and told him to handle it. The kid found the boy, told him to stop, got mouthed off at, and dropped him with one punch. Told him he'd better apologize, or he'd be back tomorrow and it would be worse. The boy apologized. A few days later the man came back with a tailor, took measurements right there in the driveway, and within the week five custom suits showed up at the door. No invoice, no explanation. You did somebody a favor, and a tailor showed up at your house.

My dad didn't live that life. He lived next to it. Close enough to know the rules, close enough to know when to say something and when to keep his mouth shut. As a kid I just thought my dad knew a lot of interesting people. He did. Some of them were more interesting than a seven-year-old needed to know about.

The Most Interesting Man in the World

If you only knew the gold records and the union halls, you'd miss the half of him I loved most — the one at home, running little cons on his own kid for the pleasure of it. He looked like Robert De Niro, my dad. Same build, same face, the man central casting sends over when the part calls for somebody you don't want to cross. Then he'd open his mouth and tell you the grass was being handled by a goat.

He had lines, and he didn't know they were lines. He'd bring home bagels, and you'd say, Dad, these are the best bagels I've ever had. And he'd look at you, dead serious: what's a matta you, you don't like 'em? You couldn't win, and that was the point. He could turn a compliment into a bit without cracking a smile. My friends and I still say it. What's a matta you, you don't like it? What's a matta you, you do? We say it to each other and we know exactly where it came from. That's the thing about a man like Lou. He leaves you his lines, and you keep saying them, and a little of him keeps showing up in your kitchen years after he's gone.

The same mouth had no filter when he'd decided something was true. A friend of my mother's married a much older man, and Lou told her, to her face, that she had father issues. Nobody had asked.

He met Donna, the woman he would marry after the divorce, with one line too. A bar and restaurant in New Jersey, Lou sitting by himself. Donna and her friends went over to grab a chair from his table, and she asked him, is anyone sitting there? You are, he said. That was the whole courtship, right there in two words. He could end a joke with a straight face and start a marriage the same way. They were together about twenty-five years.

Some afternoons he'd tape a Yankee game that had already played, then put it on for me like it was live. Rickey Henderson's gonna hit a home run here, he'd say. And Henderson would go deep. I was a little kid. I thought my father could see the future. He let me believe it for years before he told me he'd already watched the whole thing.

He got a goat. Somebody was hauling it off to the slaughterhouse, and my dad told him that if he was going to kill it, he'd take it. No discussion, no warning. One day there was a goat back there eating the grass. The man cut fifty lawns a week for a living, and his own backyard was being handled by an animal he'd talked somebody out of killing.

And everything was a surprise. What are we watching, Dad? It's a surprise. Where are we going? It's a surprise. It was usually Clint Eastwood on the screen. He loved Eastwood — the squint, the quiet, the man who didn't say much and didn't have to. That was Lou's hero, and a fair description of Lou himself. He got more joy out of the not-telling than the telling.

My brother and I called him the most interesting man in the world. It started as a joke, the guy from the Dos Equis commercials. Stay thirsty, my friends. Then we realized we weren't joking. He

really was. Not for who he knew. For who he was in a kitchen on an ordinary night, keeping a straight face, waiting for you to fall for it.

That was the man who adopted me. He never talked about himself, never needed you to know who he knew, and never once acted like any of it was special. I was proud to be his son.

CHAPTER 10 ## Oxford

“The LORD is nigh unto them that are of a broken heart.” —

Psalm 34:18

Oxford, Ohio, 1996–2000

Lou’s world had made me. Then it sent me off to build one of my own.

The first time I saw it, my dad drove me out for a wrestling visit. We came off the highway and the world turned to corn — stalks in every direction, mile after flat mile, the kind of empty a Jersey kid has no category for. It looked like we’d taken a wrong turn into Iowa. Where are we even going, I kept thinking, out here in the middle of nowhere. Then the fields gave way and there it was: red brick and old trees, one of the most beautiful campuses I’d ever seen, set down in the middle of all that farmland.

Before I ever set foot on campus, there was a party in New Jersey. Tricia Hart hosted it, a mixer for kids heading to Miami that fall. That night I met Dean Ferrera from Hawthorne and people who’d matter for years. I liked going to a school in Ohio already knowing a few faces. Dean became one of my best friends.

My mom and dad dropped me off in the fall of 1996. Partial wrestling scholarship, financial aid, Lou covering the rest. That was how it got paid for. My mom cried when she left me there. The woman who had moved two kids across a border without flinching stood in a dorm parking lot in Ohio and couldn’t stop the tears. I

didn't feel like I'd chosen Miami so much as it had chosen me first — a letter from a coach with my name on it. Later I saw it in *Newsweek*, "best schools for your money," number four. The Ivy of the Midwest.

My dorm was Stanton Hall, my roommate a good-natured Packers fan from Wisconsin with a cheesehead on his shelf and the accent to prove it. I didn't know what a cheesehead was. I'm from New Jersey. Next door was Jason Huet, six-five, a high school basketball player who'd wanted Chapel Hill and was sore his parents made him come to Miami. Hard shell, didn't let everybody in, but once he did, he didn't take it lightly. He teased me constantly — swore he couldn't understand a word I said. He texted recently: you want to come see me for Memorial Day? That's a friendship that just holds. The twins from Ramsey were there too, Kris and Kyle, the two who'd kept their hands clean at the lunch table. They became good friends too.

That was the version of me I was building at Miami. Not Claudio. Rob — county wrestling champion, Miami student, American. Nobody here knew who I'd been before I arrived. Being the darker-skinned kid on a mostly white-bread campus gave me something, and I connected in ways that hadn't come as easily in high school.

The wrestling room was in the Athletic Center, a building that smelled like liniment and decades of somebody's suffering. Chuck Angelo rarely raised his voice. He didn't need to. The expectation lived in the silence.

College wrestling isn't high school wrestling scaled up. It's a different sport under similar rules. The men I faced had been doing this since before I could read English, and they had the cheerful brutality of experienced guys who enjoy working on beginners. I got thrown. A lot. Practice was 6 a.m. and 4 p.m. You cut weight. You drilled until the moves stopped needing thought. I wasn't the most

talented wrestler on the team. What I had was what I always had: I showed up, and when it got hard I showed up harder.

Sophomore year the program got cut. Title IX. No discussion, no warning, just over. I'd like to say I was devastated — better story. What I felt was relief, the clean kind. For the first time since I was twelve, no scoreboard, no coach, no bracket. Just time.

So I had to figure out what I was doing there. I transferred into the Richard T. Farmer School of Business and declared marketing. Why marketing? Because I was bad at everything else and I could talk. People ask why I went into sales and that's the answer.

Kappa Sigma did something I didn't expect. After the standard rush, they came back for me. Not a form letter — a specific ask. I knew the feeling. The thin envelope from the coach. Lou walking into my mother's life and not leaving. I joined. For the first time I wasn't the wrestler. I was just Rob, still working out what that meant.

I was still my mother's kid underneath it. One Sunday I ended up at a church across the Indiana line, driven there at a hundred miles an hour by a man who read scripture off the steering wheel and then stood up front yelling at us like John the Baptist.

I drank. Everybody drank; that was the cover. It would be years before I understood that not everyone drank the way I did. I won't glamorize it, but the parties were great — the fun you know won't last, which is part of why it mattered. Junior year I lived in the fraternity house. Underneath it all was an insecurity I couldn't shake. The wrestling, the fraternity, the friends, and still some part of me didn't believe any of it was real.

This is the part I've never told, and without it the rest is just a list of wreckage. It was a love story. The longest, most consuming affair of my life was the one I had with my addiction. It was the kind of love that made me feel like I didn't need anyone else, and that was

the cruelest trick in it. It filled the space other people were meant to fill, and for a long time I didn't even notice they were gone.

It started at a bar in Oxford, in 1999. Justin held one out and asked if I wanted one. No, I said. I don't do drugs. It's a prescription, he said. Oh. Okay. That was the whole negotiation — the entire distance between the man I was and the man I'd become was one word, prescription, and one shrug.

The first time I took an Adderall and put alcohol on top of it, something in me went quiet that had never been quiet before. I was free of the inhibition I'd carried since I was the dark-skinned kid who didn't match the rest of the room. I was articulate without reaching for it. I was funny without trying to be funny. The part of me that stood outside every conversation, watching, grading how I was doing, finally sat down. I wasn't performing being Rob. I just was him, the version I'd always believed was in there and could never reach.

That's what nobody warns you about the beginning: it works. That first night I felt precisely how I'd always wanted to feel. And once you've felt that, once the noise stops and you meet the man you thought you were supposed to be, you'll do almost anything to get back to him.

But the freedom only came in the pills and the alcohol, and that was the cost, hidden inside the gift. Without them I felt naked. Not shy. Naked. Like I'd been dressed my whole life in borrowed confidence and now everyone could see there was nothing underneath. The inhibition came back the moment the chemicals wore off, and it came back worse, because now I knew exactly what I was missing. So I stopped letting them wear off. The thing that let me be myself was the thing I could no longer be myself without.

It split me in two. When it was good, I felt invincible, untouchable, the sharpest and funniest man in any room, certain the feeling would last forever. I could walk into a bar feeling four feet tall, and

three drinks later I'd be on the couch dancing, kissing a girl, and some sober sliver of me would watch it happen and wonder how the same person could do both. When it was bad, I was a stick of dynamite waiting to explode. The middle disappeared. The same thing that made me a god by midnight left me a live wire by morning, and the people who loved me never knew which one would walk through the door.

Someone told me once about a line in the sand at the ocean. You draw it and tell yourself, I will never go past this. Then the water comes in and washes the line away, and you draw a new one a little further back, and you tell yourself the same thing, and mean it the same amount. That was my whole using life. Never this. Then the tide came in. I kept redrawing the line further up the beach until there was no beach left, until I didn't recognize the man standing where the line used to be.

Everything that came after, the DUIs, the balcony, my mother's money turning into pills, a floor in Tijuana, was me chasing one feeling from one night. Not the high. The relief. I wasn't trying to escape myself. I was trying to get back to the only version of myself I was ever comfortable inside.

I have never been as committed to anything in my life as I was to using. It trumped all of it — the district titles, the county championship I won at seventeen, the career, MTV, the Abercrombie shoots, every accolade I ever collected trying to prove I was somebody. It beat out the people I loved. It got a devotion out of me that nothing else ever came close to, and it took everything in return.

I understand addiction now in a way I can finally explain. It doesn't mean you're using all the time. It means you want to use all the time. You can't wait for the next pill, the next drink, and some part of you is already counting down to it no matter how good the day is going.

Getting sober was not relief. It was grief. Learning to stop using meant giving up my best friend — the one who was always there when I felt four feet tall, the one who never left until it had taken everything from me. I had to mourn it. You can grieve the thing that was killing you. I did, and some days I still do.

And I won't tell you it's gone. I still carry the pattern. The substance left; the wiring didn't. These days I'm addicted to more — more work, more winning, more of whatever will fill the same hole. Recovery, for me, isn't the pattern disappearing. It's knowing it by name, and choosing every day not to feed it the one thing that almost killed me.

And some days sobriety feels like that same nakedness I used to run from. No clothing, no armor, every nerve exposed to the air. The difference now is that I stay in it. I let myself be seen with nothing on, and I don't reach for something to take the edge off.

Jason still tells one on me. We ran a case race one night — you pair off, a case of beer to a team, and whoever puts theirs down first wins. I hated losing at anything, and a case of beer was no exception. Somebody had a camera going when it caught up with me afterward: me on the bathroom floor, sick as a dog, looking up at the lens and saying, this is what I do to win. It got a big laugh. It should have gotten a second look. I could turn getting sick on a tile floor into something I'd won. They say there are always signs. That was one I wasn't ready to read.

I fell into a depression that nothing had caused. Nothing had happened to me. Everything went gray. I called my mother and she went looking for the reason — what happened, was it a girl. It wasn't a girl. I still can't explain it.

Then I called Lou. He heard it in my voice. He didn't ask follow-up questions. He said, how about I take a ride there tomorrow.

New Jersey to Ohio, ten hours, no call ahead to confirm I needed him. He took me to a doctor, got me seen, then to a chain restaurant.

Laminated menus, free refills, nothing to it but food and a booth and him across from me.

On the way out, a waitress ran into the parking lot after us and handed me her phone number. I looked at Lou. He kept walking, eyes straight ahead. I asked if he'd said something, left a big tip, set the whole thing up. He denied it flat. Didn't miss a beat. I never believed him. He took it to the grave. That might be my favorite thing about him.

A powerful true story of addiction, redemption, adoption, immigration, and the promises that carry us through our darkest nights. Rob Brizzi's journey is one of painful lessons, unlikely rescue, and the unwavering love of a man who never gave up on him. From the wrestling mats of New Jersey to the hallways of hospice care, this is a story about hope, second chances, and the cardinals that remind us we are never alone.



ROB BRIZZI is a recovering addict and a Certified Dementia Practitioner (CDP) who works as a hospice liaison. Born in Mexico City and raised in New Jersey, he lives in Raleigh, North Carolina, with his wife, Hope.